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Mozilla launched an ad-blocker for iOS called Focus, which ironically isn't allowed to work with Firefox for iOS. <http://dgit.in/MozillaFocus>

Bazaar

Sony RX100 IV

The tiny imaging legend

The Sony RX100 IV presents itself as one of the smallest compact cameras, with extensive manual controls and great image quality. It is made of good quality metal, with a single rubber thumbstrip. Buttons are neatly laid out, and the concealment of the electronic viewfinder and the flash module are well thought out. It is light, and coupled with wrist suspender hooks, should take care of no hand grip on the body.

It has a new 1-inch Exmor RS sensor, maximum continuous shooting rate has increased to 16fps, and the electronic shutter can shoot at up to 1/32000 seconds. Another notable upgrade over previous generations is 4K video shooting. The NP-BX1 battery pack, with battery stamina of 1240mAh, is rated to last for 280 shots. The electronic viewfinder now has a resolution of 2.36 million pixels, in place of 1.44 million pixels on RX100 III. The Sony RX100 IV does not feature a hot shoe that was last seen on the RX100 Mark II, owing to the built-in flash module and the pop-up electronic viewfinder. The Zeiss Vario-Sonnar T* 24-70mm f/1.8 lens remains the same – and is great. It has a limited range which may pose a few problems, but is compact, and fast.

The electronic viewfinder on the RX100 IV is sharp, accurate, and shifts actively between the live view display and itself, with the help of a proximity sensor. In terms of shooting capabilities, the RX100 does miss the power of interchangeable lenses that compact-body mirrorless cameras have, but within the compact shell, provides complete manual control over photographs. Focusing manually is smooth with the EVF, and while the autofocus mechanism works when the subject is in extreme closeup range, it fails to lock focus, even when the subject is stationary.

Shutter speeds range from 30" to 1/2000" (mechanical) and 1/32000 (electronic). The lens ranges between f/1.8 to f/11. At f/1.8, images have a certain amount of distortion, and at f/11, there is softening on the edges because of light leaking through the iris. However, the 1-inch Exmor RS sensor in this tiny device makes it one of the best, or possibly the best compact camera available today. Images in daylight, overcast and indoor (tungsten and fluorescent) look sharp and crisp, and render true-to-source colours while preserving contrast and brightness levels. At dawn or dusk, or while shooting into the light, its excellent dynamic range gets you more details, and good balance of light and shadows.



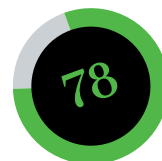
Shooting at objects in shadow with a singular light source in the background gives good levels of detail on the subject, and light sources do not appear overpowering or harsh. This is also useful when you shoot in harsh sunlight, where the shadows in trees or buildings are not completely darkened.

The 4K video recording is smooth, noise levels are reasonably low even at ISO levels of up to 1250, meaning that you can actually use it to shoot videos in poorly-lit situations. The autofocus mechanism does pose a problem here, and I found myself focusing manually more often, which might be a slight deterrent in an otherwise excellent camera which literally fits into trouser pockets. The tiltable LCD display is another benefit, although the presence of touchscreen and the ability to swivel it would have made it even better.

All of this, however, comes at the expense of one thing – battery. The 1240mAh battery pack is weaker than what the Sony RX100 Mark III had, and on regular usage, you will need to charge it halfway through third day of shooting. Approximately, that is about 180 photographs, and 12 minutes of 1080p videos – something that is a major letdown for a pocket device that is otherwise ideal to take around, wherever you go.

The Sony RX100 Mark IV is one of the best compact cameras made till date, providing full manual control and good dynamic range, thus making it a very versatile camera. However, the lack of touchscreen input and a mis-functioning autofocus mechanism means that it has its limitations. The asking price may seem steep, but for such a compact device with great image quality, the RX100 IV makes absolute sense.

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Specifications

Resolution: 20.1 million effective pixels, **Sensor size and type:** 1.0-type (13.2 mm x 8.8 mm) Exmor RS CMOS sensor, aspect ratio 3:2, **Lens:** ZEISS® Vario-Sonnar T* lens, 10 elements in 9 groups (9 aspherical elements including AA lens), **Image processor:** BIONZ X, **Viewfinder:** 3-inch Xtra Fine TFT LCD, electronic viewfinder, **Shutter speed:** 1/32000" to 30", **ISO:** 100-12800, **Weight:** 271 grams (body only), **Connectivity:** WiFi

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